

Comments on Meditation

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Is Descartes right to say ‘that there are never any sure signs by means of which being awake can be distinguished from being asleep’?

In my opinion, it is right to say so. And it is also easy to prove. For all kinds of sure signs, it is impossible for us to distinguish whether it is a sure sign that can help distinguish awake from asleep, or is it a sign deceived by an evil demon making us believe that it is a sign that can do so. Therefore, any sure signs detected by an individual can’t help distinguish it being awake or asleep.

But what about a sign that is distinguished by another individual?

To answer that, we have to go a step further. We may realize that for awake and asleep, they are all about a state. A state that acts totally the same among the set of things the state is describing. It is possible that there exist two degenerate states of a set of things that is impossible for the set of things to distinguish among evidence selected among them, but do have difference in terms of a thing not included in the set of things. To make it clear, an example could be it being hardly possible for a person to distinguish whether (s)he is awake or asleep, but easily distinguished by a person standing next to him. Also, it is impossible for a person to distinguish whether (s)he is a brain in a vat or a person in real world, but easily distinguished by a scientist standing next to the vat.

Therefore, we reached the idea——To distinguish the state of a set of things, or to prove the existence of a set of things, it is impossible to prove it between the set of things but easy to prove it through things not being included by the set.

Now, we can prove an even stronger statement, **there are never any sure signs by means of which being awake can be distinguished from being asleep, no matter the sign is detected by an individual or another.** The proof is simple. Any existence of sure signs detected by a different individual has to be proved by another individual. Therefore, no matter how many individuals we have, we always need a new individual. Thus, the proof never ends.

Brainstorming

It is believed that no one would be willing to sacrifice real-life experiences for the sake of happiness in a brain-in-a-vat scenario. But would you be willing to live a beggar-life in a world outside the universe, making the universe being a vat to the world, and to sacrifice the real-life experiences in the universe? If no, why is there a contradictory?